Who Has What, and Who Opens the Mail?

A guide to the family conversation about Mom's application paperwork.

Your sister has Mom's checkbook, you have the mail, and your brother has the box from her desk. Each of you has part of the picture, and the people who prepare the application will need one account of it.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: get who holds which records, who is watching the mail and what nobody knows yet onto one page. It isn't for deciding anything about the application.

Who should be there

Mom, if she is able and wants to be. These are her records, and she may know where things are. Then everyone who holds any of her papers, pays any of her bills or picks up her mail. Someone who can't come can send a list of what they have.

Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

How to open

Start with what each person has, not with what should happen. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau says that even if it feels awkward, it is important to have an honest conversation about finances. [1]

- “Each of us has some of Mom's papers. Can we put on one page who has what?”
- “Mom, we're pulling your records together for the application. Is there anything you know of that we haven't found?”
- Say what the conversation is for: one list. Say what it isn't for: deciding when to apply, how anything on the application is answered, or what a letter means.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom, if she's able

1. Which accounts, policies or papers do you have that we might not know about?

2. Where do you keep the things we haven't found?

Ask each other

1. Which of Mom's records do you have, and what dates do they cover?

2. Who is getting her mail now, and who opens it?

3. Has anyone already sent anything in, or been asked for something? What was it, and when?

4. Where does what you remember differ from what someone else here remembers, or from what the paper shows?

5. What can't any of us find or explain yet?

6. Which of our questions are we leaving for a professional: when to apply, which documents are needed, what happens if more information is asked for?

How to write down what was said

Write who has each record and who does each job, not what any of it means. Where two people remember something differently, write both and don't settle it. The people who prepare the application will want to know about both versions.

RECORD OR JOB	WHO HAS IT OR DOES IT	DATES OR DETAILS	REMEMBERED DIFFERENTLY BY
Bank statements, checking account	Karen	This year's. Earlier ones not found yet.	
Opening Mom's mail	Me	When I'm at the house. Letters about the application go in the blue folder.	
The life insurance policy	David thinks it's in the box at his place	Not looked at yet	Karen remembers Mom cashing it in

What not to decide yet

These go to your Medicaid planner, an applications specialist or an elder law attorney, and the page you're writing is what you bring them. Leave them open.

- When to apply.
- How any question on the application is answered.
- What a letter from the Medicaid agency means, or how to reply to it.

- Whether to move, close or change anything in Mom's accounts or property.
- Who remembered it right.

What you can decide today

- Who keeps the folder, and where.
- Who opens the mail, and who they tell when a letter about the application arrives.
- Who keeps the list of what has been sent and what has been asked for.
- Who takes each open question to a professional.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, decide anything about the application, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets your family to one page, with the differences and the unknowns left on it. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has one page now: who holds which records, who is watching the mail and which questions you're leaving for a professional. The planning interview takes it further: it asks about your family's situation, question by question, and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness